

digital skillsets. “Obviously, I don’t expect a regional sales person for a pharmaceutical firm to have social media skills. But I’m looking for a certain personality profile—leadership ability, interests and ambition,” says Aditya Mishra, Director and CEO, CIEL HR Services. Their LinkedIn posts and network serve as a window into who they are, he adds.

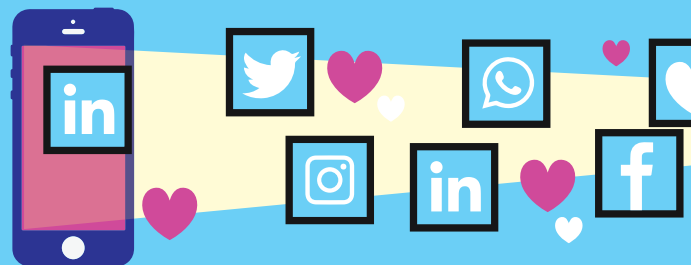
LinkedIn and Twitter are the usual suspects when it comes to the sites looked at, agree recruiters. But Facebook and Instagram are not entirely ruled out. Sterling also looks at Pinterest, YouTube and news sources. Still others prefer peeking into software development platform GitHub, question-and-answer website Quora and corporate community knowledge base CiteHR as well to glean domain-related insights about the candidates. But all experts say they only look at publicly available information. However, they also agree that many organisations do resort to probing into private profiles and data scraping without consent.

Depending on the seniority of the role, the hiring manager and the organisation, the checking varies from a cursory glance at the websites to a full-blown analysis. Sterling, which uses technology, applies filters or keywords like drugs, misogynistic and violence, that throws up problematic content by the person, if any. Used in various combinations and across volumes of data available online, says Sterling’s Sinha, it becomes impossible to do just a manual check. “It has to first be done by a machine and then summarised for a human eye to look at.”

The process assumes more significance for senior management and strategic positions where a hiring misstep works out to be a lot costlier.

“If I do a wrong CEO hire, I could be bringing down the P&L and dragging down share prices a couple of notches. So, the impact is much higher,” says Sushant Dwivedy, MD (India and the Philippines) at talent

MANUAL SOCIAL MEDIA SCREENING CAN COST ₹900 PER EMPLOYEE. A COMPREHENSIVE BACKGROUND CHECK INCLUDING TECHNOLOGY-ENABLED SOCIAL MEDIA SCREENING CAN EVEN COST CLOSE TO ₹3,500. THE RATES VARY DEPENDING ON THE VOLUME



LENS ON SOCIAL MEDIA

Candidates’ social media accounts are increasingly under scrutiny from recruiters



● A 2020 poll among 1,005 American hiring decision-makers by US-based staffing solutions firm Express Employment Professionals found 67 per cent respondents saying they use social networking sites to research potential job candidates



● Among them, 55 per cent found content that caused them not to hire the applicant



● But 21 per cent said they are not likely to consider a candidate who doesn’t have an online presence



● A 2018 survey of 1,000+ hiring decision makers by employment website CareerBuilder also threw up similar results of 70 per cent, 57 per cent and 47 per cent, respectively, for the same metrics



● While a similar study is not available in the Indian context, the red flags pointed out by several HR experts and the study were almost the same

screening firm SHL. The digging can go back as far as seven years, which Sterling considers the gold standard in any kind of data analysis. Luthra prefers breadth over depth, going back only a year across activities, giving candidates the benefit that they may have changed over the years.

But it’s not always done with the intention of digging up dirt. “It’s like getting an insurance policy. You would hope you don’t need it but in the event that you do, you just feel terrible to not have done it,” says Sinha.

The information gathered can also serve as conversation starters during the interview,